Troubleshooting OTel Pipelines

> **Series:** OTEL | **Notebook:** 8 of 8 | **Created:** January 2026

Debugging OpenTelemetry Data Flows

When telemetry data doesn't arrive as expected, systematic troubleshooting is essential. This notebook covers common issues, diagnostic techniques, and resolution steps for OpenTelemetry pipelines.

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Prerequisites

Requirement	Details
Knowledge	OTEL-01 through OTEL-07
Access	Collector logs, application logs

1. Troubleshooting Methodology

Systematic Approach

```
1. Identify the symptom
   ↓
2. Check component by component
   SDK → Collector → Backend
   ↓
3. Verify configuration
   ↓
4. Test connectivity
   ↓
5. Apply fix
   ↓
6. Verify resolution
```

Symptom Categories

Symptom	Likely Issue	Start Here
No data at all	Connectivity, auth	Section 4
Partial data	Filtering, sampling	Section 5
Delayed data	Performance	Section 6
Wrong data	Configuration	Section 5
Collector crashes	Resources	Section 6

2. Collector Issues

Collector Won't Start

Check configuration syntax:

```
# Validate config
otelcol-contrib validate --config=config.yaml
```

Common configuration errors:

Error	Cause	Fix
`unknown type`	Invalid component name	Check spelling, verify contrib has component
`duplicate key`	YAML syntax error	Check indentation
`no pipelines defined`	Missing service section	Add service.pipelines

Enable Debug Logging

```
service:
  telemetry:
    logs:
      level: debug
```

Collector Dropping Data

Check queue status:

```
# If using zpages extension
curl http://localhost:55679/debug/tracez
```

Common causes:

Cause	Indicator	Fix
Memory pressure	OOM, restarts	Increase memory_limiter limits
Export failure	Retry logs	Check backend connectivity
Queue full	Queue overflow logs	Increase queue size or consumers

3. SDK Issues

No Spans Generated

Python:

```
# Enable SDK debug logging
import logging
logging.basicConfig(level=logging.DEBUG)

# Verify tracer provider is set
from opentelemetry import trace
print(trace.get_tracer_provider())
# Should NOT be NoOpTracerProvider
```

Java:

```
# Enable agent debug
java -javaagent:opentelemetry-javaagent.jar \
  -Dotel.javaagent.debug=true \
  -jar app.jar
```

Common SDK Issues

Issue	Cause	Fix
NoOpTracer	Provider not set	Call set_tracer_provider()
No export	Processor not added	Add BatchSpanProcessor
Missing spans	Not in context	Use start_as_current_span
Lost context	Async not handled	Use context propagation

Async Context Loss

```
# Wrong - loses context
async def bad_example():
    with tracer.start_as_current_span("parent"):
        await asyncio.gather(
            child_task(),  # No context
            child_task()
        )

# Right - preserves context
async def good_example():
    with tracer.start_as_current_span("parent"):
        token = context.attach(context.get_current())
        try:
            await asyncio.gather(
                child_task(),
                child_task()
            )
        finally:
            context.detach(token)
```

4. Connectivity Issues

Test Collector Connectivity

```
# Test OTLP endpoint
curl -v http://collector:4318/v1/traces \
  -X POST \
  -H "Content-Type: application/json" \
  -d '{}'

# Test gRPC (with grpcurl)
grpcurl -plaintext collector:4317 list
```

Test Dynatrace Connectivity

```
# Test OTLP endpoint (set DT_API_TOKEN env var first)
curl -v https://${DT_ENV_ID}.live.dynatrace.com/api/v2/otlp/v1/traces \
  -X POST \
  -H "Authorization: Api-Token ${DT_API_TOKEN}" \
  -H "Content-Type: application/json" \
  -d '{}'

# Expected: 200 OK (empty body is fine)
```

Common Connectivity Errors

Error	Cause	Fix
`connection refused`	Wrong port/host	Verify endpoint
`401 Unauthorized`	Invalid token	Check token, regenerate
`403 Forbidden`	Missing scope	Add required scope to token
`certificate error`	TLS issue	Check certs, disable verify for test
`timeout`	Network/firewall	Check firewall rules

Proxy Issues

```
# Collector proxy configuration
exporters:
  otlphttp:
    endpoint: https://tenant.live.dynatrace.com/api/v2/otlp
    proxy_url: http://proxy.example.com:8080
```

```
# Or via environment
export HTTPS_PROXY=http://proxy.example.com:8080
```

5. Data Quality Issues

Missing Attributes

Debug exporter to see data:

```
exporters:
  debug:
    verbosity: detailed

service:
  pipelines:
    traces:
      exporters: [debug, otlphttp]
```

service.name Missing

Without `service.name`, Dynatrace can't create service entities:

```
# Add default service.name in collector
processors:
  resource:
    attributes:
      - key: service.name
        value: "unknown-service"
        action: insert  # Only adds if missing
```

Wrong Time Zone

```
# Ensure collector uses UTC
# In Kubernetes:
env:
  - name: TZ
    value: UTC
```

Data Being Filtered

Check filter processor configuration:

```
processors:
  filter:
    traces:
      span:
        # This filters OUT matching spans
        - 'attributes["http.url"] == "/health"'
```

6. Performance Issues

Collector Memory Issues

Symptoms:
- OOMKilled restarts
- Slow processing
- Data drops

Fixes:

```
processors:
  memory_limiter:
    check_interval: 1s
    limit_mib: 1500      # Increase limit
    spike_limit_mib: 500 # Allow spikes

  batch:
    timeout: 5s           # Faster flush
    send_batch_size: 500  # Smaller batches
```

High Latency

Causes and fixes:

Cause	Indicator	Fix
Large batches	Delayed export	Reduce batch size
Slow export	Backend latency	Increase parallelism
Too many processors	Processing time	Remove unnecessary processors

```
exporters:
  otlphttp:
    sending_queue:
      num_consumers: 10  # More parallel exports
```

SDK Overhead

```
# Use sampling to reduce volume
from opentelemetry.sdk.trace.sampling import TraceIdRatioBased

provider = TracerProvider(
    sampler=TraceIdRatioBased(0.1),  # 10% sampling
    resource=resource
)
```

7. Diagnostic Tools

Collector zpages

```
extensions:
  zpages:
    endpoint: 0.0.0.0:55679

service:
  extensions: [zpages]
```

Access:
- `http://collector:55679/debug/servicez` - Service info
- `http://collector:55679/debug/pipelinez` - Pipeline status
- `http://collector:55679/debug/extensionz` - Extensions
- `http://collector:55679/debug/tracez` - Trace samples

Health Check

```
extensions:
  health_check:
    endpoint: 0.0.0.0:13133
```

```
curl http://collector:13133/
# {"status":"Server available"}
```

pprof Profiling

```
extensions:
  pprof:
    endpoint: 0.0.0.0:1777
```

```
go tool pprof http://collector:1777/debug/pprof/heap
```

```
// Check OTel data arrival
fetch spans, from: now() - 1h
| filter isNotNull(otel.library.name)
| summarize count = count(), by:{time_bucket = bin(timestamp, 5m)}
| sort time_bucket asc
```

```
// Find services without service.name
fetch spans, from: now() - 1h
| filter isNull(service.name) or service.name == ""
| summarize count = count(), by:{otel.library.name}
| sort count desc
```

8. Common Fixes

Quick Reference

Problem	Fix
No data at all	Check endpoint, auth token, network
No service entity	Add service.name resource attribute
Collector OOM	Increase memory_limiter, reduce batch size
High cardinality	Remove dynamic attributes
Context lost	Use context propagation in async
Wrong time	Set TZ=UTC
SSL errors	Check certs, add CA

Collector Config Template

A production-ready template:

```
receivers:
  otlp:
    protocols:
      grpc:
        endpoint: 0.0.0.0:4317
      http:
        endpoint: 0.0.0.0:4318

processors:
  memory_limiter:
    check_interval: 1s
    limit_mib: 1500
    spike_limit_mib: 500
  batch:
    timeout: 10s
    send_batch_size: 1000
  resource:
    attributes:
      - key: service.name
        value: unknown
        action: insert

exporters:
  otlphttp:
    endpoint: https://${DT_ENV}.live.dynatrace.com/api/v2/otlp
    headers:
      Authorization: Api-Token ${DT_TOKEN}
    retry_on_failure:
      enabled: true
      initial_interval: 5s
      max_interval: 30s

extensions:
  health_check:
  zpages:

service:
  extensions: [health_check, zpages]
  telemetry:
    logs:
      level: info
  pipelines:
    traces:
      receivers: [otlp]
      processors: [memory_limiter, resource, batch]
      exporters: [otlphttp]
    metrics:
```

```
      receivers: [otlp]
      processors: [memory_limiter, resource, batch]
      exporters: [otlphttp]
    logs:
      receivers: [otlp]
      processors: [memory_limiter, resource, batch]
      exporters: [otlphttp]
```

Summary

In this notebook, you learned:

- Systematic troubleshooting methodology
- Collector debugging and configuration validation
- SDK issue diagnosis and async context handling
- Connectivity testing and common errors
- Data quality issue resolution
- Performance tuning for memory and latency
- Diagnostic tools: zpages, health check, pprof
- Quick fixes for common problems

References

- Collector Troubleshooting
- SDK Debugging
- Dynatrace OTel Troubleshooting
